

The 6:15

WEDNESDAY · SEPTEMBER 23, 2026

NO. 18

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Wed 9/23 (today)	S&P Global flash PMIs 9:45a ET (cons. composite 55.2, mfg. 53.0, services 56.4). Pezeshkian addresses UN General Assembly this morning — see Lead. CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House-ban lawsuit gets a hearing before Judge Timothy J. Kelly this afternoon [NEW] — see Politics.
Thu 9/24	Initial claims (cons. 201K) & new home sales (cons. 0.626M), 8:30a/10a ET. Costco fiscal Q4 earnings after the close — cons. \$6.55 EPS on \$94.85B revenue.
Fri 9/25	Durable goods orders (cons. -0.4%; ex-transport +0.4%), 8:30a ET. Michigan sentiment, final.
Mon 9/28	Starship Flight 14 — SpaceX's first orbital Starship test, NET this date per the FAA's current airspace advisory (12:15-14:14 UTC / 8:15-10:14a ET), 26 Starlink V3 sats aboard; slipped twice already (from 9/18, then 9/22) [dates indicative] .
Tue 9/29	Case-Shiller home prices; JOLTs (cons. 7.24M openings); consumer confidence (cons. 89).
Wed 9/30	Core PCE — the Fed's preferred gauge (cons. +0.3% m/m, +3.4% y/y); GDP final Q2 (cons. +1.5%); ADP employment. Micron fiscal Q4 earnings after the close.
Thu 10/1 – Fri 10/2	ISM manufacturing; Nike fiscal Q1 earnings (Thu). Nonfarm payrolls Fri (cons. +90K, unemployment 4.1%).
FOMC	Oct. 27-28 — ~5 weeks out, outside this window. CME FedWatch prices a 25bp hike at 59.7%; Polymarket closer to 54/46 [trackers diverge] .
AI/VC [NEW, retro. 24-48h]	OpenAI shipped GPT-6 Sol (half Astra-tier pricing: \$2/\$10 per M tokens) and GPT-6 Luna Tue. Xiaomi released MiMo-V2.6 (omnimodal Pro + 309B/15B-active MoE) on Hugging Face under MIT license Mon.

Cognition raised a \$2B Series E (a16z, Accel, Founders Fund, General Catalyst) for its AI coding-agent business **[single-sourced]**.

METRICS · AS OF ~6:15A ET UNLESS NOTED

Oil	Brent settled ~\$98.40 Tue — a sixth straight losing session on Iran-diplomacy hopes; a live tracker at 6:18a ET today showed \$99.43 (+0.55%/24h) [pre-market tick, no Wed settle yet] . WTI settled \$95.59 Mon (-4.69%); Tue's WTI settle not located this run [not confirmed as of press time] . Spread not calculable same-day given the gap.
Rates	10Y 4.96% (Mon); CNBC called Tue's move "little changed" but no fresh close located this run. 2Y 4.743% (Tue, -1bp). 30Y 5.296% (Tue, unch.).
FX/Vol/Gold	DXY 100.6 (Tue) — highest since late July, on hawkish-Fed repricing. VIX: no fresh print located this run; last confirmed 14.81 (Fri 9/18) [not confirmed as of press time] . Gold \$4,314.38, -1.14% (Wed a.m.) — fell below \$4,350 as hawkish Fed commentary outweighed falling oil.
Equities (Tue 9/22 close)	Dow 51,864 (-0.36%, -185pts); S&P 500 7,764 (+0.02%, flat); Nasdaq Comp. 27,244 (+0.5%, fresh record). Vs. Fri 9/18 (issue No. 17): Dow +0.35% wk, S&P +1.48%, Nasdaq +2.72%.
Asia/Europe/Gas	Hang Seng 24,891.08, -0.78% as of 09:44 HKT [intraday tick, not a close] ; Nikkei/European closes not confirmed this run. Retail gas \$4.4750/gal natl. avg (AAA, Tue), up from \$4.4687 Fri.
Crude: ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month. Rates: Fed H.15/CME. Equities: exchange closes/CNBC/Bloomberg.	
HORMUZ COUNTERS	
Transits	IMF PortWatch: 1 vessel Sept. 20 vs. an 85/day pre-crisis baseline (~1% of normal). Kpler's most recent figure checked this run (13/day 10-day avg.) dates to early Sept. and is stale, not repeated as current; no fresher Windward or Lloyd's List count located.
Dark tankers/AIS	60 tankers lost AIS signal in the past 24h of 166 screened (2.2x ambient dropout), per a tracker checked 10:18 UTC today. Separately, 373 AIS-visible

ships held in the watch zone away from berth; 7-day avg. 340, range 256-496 — an updated series, not a continuation of issue No. 14's stale 490 figure.

War-risk premia

Same tracker: ~\$10.0M/VLCC passage, ~40x pre-crisis. Well below issue No. 16's carried figure (3%-10% of hull value, ~\$21M high end on a \$210M VLCC, per earlier Lloyd's List reporting) **[not reconciled]** — different methodologies at different points in the crisis; treat as a wide, moving range.

Strikes

Two tankers hit Sept. 21 **[NEW]**: crude tanker LR Stephanie hit by an unidentified projectile (2 crew injured, continued under own power); an LPG carrier hit by debris (all 19 crew, incl. 9 Indian nationals, safe; anchored Khor Fakkan, UAE). No verified running strike total located this run.

Closures

Strait remains under partial Iranian closure/counter-blockade; Day 206-207 of the crisis per multiple trackers. No change in status this run.

PortWatch, Kpler, Windward, and Lloyd's List/hull-premia figures measure different things (vessel counts, percentages, dollars) over different windows — never netted or averaged.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees

Lost the Arizona finale 8-4 Sun. (Arenado's 3rd grand slam of the season), resolving issue No. 17's open score. Split a doubleheader vs. Tampa Bay Tue. — won G1 2-0 (Rodón: 8IP, 3H) but lost G2 1-6, and the Rays clinched the AL East with that win (home-field edge through the AL playoffs). Yankees now 90-67; clinched a playoff berth Sept. 14, playing for seeding.

Knicks

No trades/signings; the NBA published MSG's preseason slate Tue. — Oct. 5 at Philadelphia, then home Oct. 8 (Wizards), 12 (Timberwolves), 15 (Raptors), plus Oct. 13 at Toronto.

Northwestern

No reported moves since issue No. 17; next game not yet confirmed this run.

LEAD

MARKET PRICES A DEAL THAT HASN'T HAPPENED

Oil falls for a sixth straight session on an Iran "very good meeting" and a specific 7-day reopening offer — but the strait itself hasn't moved

The market spent Tuesday pricing a diplomatic breakthrough that, on the water, hasn't happened yet. Brent has now fallen for six consecutive sessions, settling near \$98.40 Tuesday before ticking back up to \$99.43 in early Wednesday trade, after President Trump told reporters that U.S. officials — envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner — had just concluded a "very good," three-hour meeting with Iran's delegation, led by Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly. [fact] A second meeting is being planned. [fact] The timing is notable: Trump's own UN address hours earlier was combative, repeating a threat to "annihilate" Iran, which makes the sit-down that followed read less like momentum and more like both sides keeping a channel open despite the public rhetoric. [read]

The more concrete news came separately: a senior Iranian official told Reuters Tuesday that Iran can reopen the Strait of Hormuz within seven days if the U.S. eases military pressure and lifts its blockade of Iranian ports. [fact, single-sourced to Reuters as relayed] That is the first time Tehran has attached a specific performance period to reopening, rather than describing it as a standing condition or an open-ended negotiation — it converts the strait from a posture into a dated, conditional transaction. [read] But the condition is doing all the work: the U.S. counter-blockade of Iranian ports is still in place, nothing checked this run indicates Washington has agreed to ease it, and the strait today is running at roughly 1% of its pre-crisis transit volume (1 vessel Sept. 20 against an 85/day baseline,

per IMF PortWatch — see Hormuz counters). [fact] Two tankers were hit inside the strait as recently as Monday. [fact] A seven-day offer is a data point about Iranian intent, not evidence the clock has started. [read]

Framing it further: Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian arrived in New York and addresses the General Assembly this morning, after hardliners at home — the ultraconservative Kayhan newspaper explicitly — pressured him to skip the trip or use it as, in Kayhan's words, a "courtroom for American crimes." [fact] That he went anyway, alongside a delegation empowered to meet U.S. envoys, is being read by regional coverage as hardliners "making room for diplomacy," though that read is inference dressed as reporting and should be treated as such until the speech and any follow-on meeting happen. [flag/read]

The macro backdrop complicates a clean "risk-off unwind" story. The dollar index is at 100.6, its highest since late July, and gold fell below \$4,350 Wednesday morning — normally the signature of geopolitical risk premium coming out of markets, consistent with the oil move. But both are also consistent with a second, separate driver: a Federal Reserve that has turned hawkish enough that CME FedWatch now prices a 59.7% chance of another 25bp hike at the Oct. 27-28 meeting (Polymarket has it closer to 54/46), which pulls the dollar up and gold down on its own, independent of Iran. [read] Meanwhile equities split the difference — the Nasdaq closed at a fresh record Tuesday (up 2.72% on the week) while the Dow slipped 0.36% — a pattern more consistent with a market chasing an AI-earnings and rate story than one primarily trading Hormuz. [read] The honest read: six days of falling oil is real and Iran-linked, but it's happening inside a market that has multiple things to price at once,

and none of Tuesday's numbers by themselves prove the strait is any closer to actually reopening than it was in issue No. 17's account three days ago. [read]

POLITICS

CNN, MS NOW and Politico sued the Trump administration Monday over Friday's White House access ban, naming Trump, communications director Steven Cheung, Secret Service Director Sean Curran and chief of staff Susie Wiles as defendants and alleging First Amendment and due-process violations. [NEW — resolves issue No. 17's "no litigation filed" flag] The complaint, filed in federal court in Washington, argues the ban is a "direct assault" on constitutional protections for newsgathering and speech — the outlets are seeking injunctive relief restoring access rather than damages. [fact] U.S. District Judge Timothy J. Kelly, assigned the case, set a videoconference hearing for this (Wednesday) afternoon — after this issue's press time, so no ruling to report. [fact] Other television networks refused to provide White House pool coverage Monday in solidarity with CNN's exclusion, an unusual show of cross-outlet coordination with no confirmed precedent this cycle. [fact] The White House Correspondents' Association's original reinstatement demand (issue No. 17) has not been met.

ECONOMICS

The dollar's push to a five-month high and gold's slide below \$4,350 both trace to the same source: Fed officials leaning hawkish enough that October-hike odds are now a real split rather than a formality, with CME FedWatch (59.7%) and Polymarket (54%) telling different stories about how close that call is. [read] That's a shift

from the market's posture a week ago, when a rate cut, not a hike, was the base case discussion (issue No. 15/16) — a genuine reversal in the rates conversation, not noise. [read] The data that could resolve it is stacked at the end of next week: core PCE and GDP's final Q2 read both land Sept. 30, four days before this issue would next need to explain a move either way. [fact] Durable goods Friday and Thursday's claims/new-home-sales prints are the more immediate inputs on the growth side, ahead of a payrolls report Oct. 2 that at a 90K consensus is already priced for a soft labor market. [read] The two-year yield (4.743%, -1bp Tue.) is the cleaner read on Fed-path repricing than the 10-year, which still carries the Hormuz risk premium the short end mostly doesn't — worth watching whether that spread moves as the diplomacy track develops. [read]

BUSINESS

Costco reports fiscal Q4 after Thursday's close, with consensus at \$6.55 EPS on \$94.85B revenue (+10% y/y) — the next test, after FedEx's beat-and-conservative-guide combination (issue No. 17), of whether consumer and wholesale demand is holding up under the tariff and rate backdrop. [fact] Micron follows Sept. 30; management has already guided to record quarterly revenue near \$50B and gross margins around 86%, a bar set by AI-memory demand (HBM) rather than the PC/phone cycle that used to drive the stock — worth watching whether that guide holds against this week's more hawkish rate backdrop. [fact/read] Nike reports Oct. 1 — see Calendar for the full earnings cluster. Nothing new located this run on the Amazon FTC ad-auction suit or Ford/CATL battery scrutiny flagged in prior issues; both remain open items without fresh developments. [continuity]

TECHNOLOGY

OpenAI shipped two new models Tuesday: GPT-6 Sol, priced at half its GPT-5.6-tier rate (\$2/\$10 per million tokens vs. \$4/\$20) and pitched as "cut from the same cloth" as flagship Astra, alongside GPT-6 Luna. [NEW] The pricing move reads as a response to open-weight competition rather than a pure capability play — the same day, Xiaomi put its MiMo-V2.6 series on Hugging Face under an MIT license, including a 309B-parameter (15B active) mixture-of-experts model with 256K context, free to self-host. [NEW] Separately, Cognition raised a \$2B Series E from a16z, Accel, Founders Fund and General Catalyst for its AI coding-agent business — a large single check even by this year's standards, though single-sourced this run and not yet confirmed via a second outlet. [NEW, flag] Nvidia's Hugging Face acquisition and Anthropic's IPO financing talks (both covered in prior issues) had no fresh development located this run. [continuity]

GEOPOLITICS

Russia bombarded at least four Ukrainian regions overnight into Tuesday with missiles and drones, killing five, while Ukrainian forces struck another Russian oil refinery with a long-range strike — a broader, multi-region barrage distinct from Friday's Sumy building strike and Saturday's separate Sumy FPV attack covered in issue No. 17. [NEW, tag distinct from prior Sumy-specific items] The strikes came as Volodymyr Zelenskyy arrived in New York for UN General Assembly meetings with Trump and other leaders. [fact] Separately, the "Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act" — the bill flagged as pending in issue No. 16 — was signed into law by Trump on Friday, Sept. 18; it authorizes tariffs on top buyers of Russian energy and targets Russia's shadow tanker fleet. [NEW — resolves prior issue's signing-timeline flag]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the Lead's diplomacy track, the Salalah multilateral meeting remains stalled with no rescheduled date, and issue No. 16's dueling accounts of who forced the postponement are still unresolved this run. [continuity] Monday's two tanker strikes (LR Stephanie and an LPG carrier — see Hormuz counters) are the freshest evidence that the sea-lane itself is unchanged in status even as the diplomatic track moves; the strait remains under partial closure, Day 206-207 of the crisis by trackers' count. [continuity] War-risk premia readings diverge sharply between this run's tracker (~\$10M/VLCC passage) and the Lloyd's List-sourced figure carried in issue No. 16 (~\$21M high end) — flagged rather than reconciled; see Hormuz counters for the full methodology note. Worth naming explicitly: the seven-day

reopening offer covered in the Lead is a statement of Iranian willingness, not a ceasefire on the water — nothing checked this run indicates Iran has stood down the forces conducting Monday's strikes, and a week-long publicly stated offer is also a week in which either side could act to make the timeline moot. [read]

SPORTS

Yankees	Lost Arizona finale 8-4 Sun. (Arenado grand slam); split Tue. DH vs. Tampa Bay, won 2-0/lost 1-6. 90-67, clinched playoff berth Sept. 14, playing for seeding; Rays clinched the AL East on the nightcap loss.
Knicks	No trades/signings; NBA released MSG's preseason schedule, opens Oct. 5 at Philadelphia. Defending champions; preseason begins in two weeks.
Northwestern	No game since beating Colorado 41-7 Sat. 9/19; no reported moves. Wildcats 2-0.

Continuity. Resolved this run: the Arizona finale score (Yankees lost, not the pending split), the CNN/Politico/MS NOW litigation status (filed, hearing today), the Russia sanctions bill's signing (done, Sept. 18, now named for Lindsey Graham). Not refreshed this run: a verified running total of Hormuz strikes; Tuesday's WTI settle; a fresh VIX print; Nikkei/European closes; the Amazon FTC suit and Ford/CATL scrutiny; Nvidia-Hugging Face and Anthropic IPO financing (no new development). Watch for next issue: the outcome of today's CNN/Politico/MS NOW hearing before Judge Kelly; Pezeshkian's UNGA remarks and any second US-Iran meeting; whether Iran's 7-day reopening offer gets any US response; Costco's Thursday earnings; Starship Flight 14's Sept. 28 window (already slipped twice).

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.